Blindsided

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A story by Alain Désilets and ChatGPT

There was something about Sharkey's that made it impossible to take yourself too seriously. Maybe it was the battered vintage arcade machines in the corner that hadn't worked since 2009, or the fact that the entire bar smelled faintly of stale beer and old carpet. Or maybe it was that the place sat directly between the Engineering building and the alley where the campus raccoons held their nightly turf wars.

Whatever the reason, it was where Lena and Daniel ended up on most Friday nights, wedged into a booth near the back, their laptops buried under notebooks and their drink tabs running longer than their neural net training logs.

Tonight though, there were no laptops. Just the kind of end-of-the-line energy that comes when you are finally, **finally,** almost done.

"So, that's it," Daniel said, lifting his pint. "Just the thesis defense, and a little ceremonial groveling, and they'll hand me a diploma with my name misspelled."

Lena raised her glass but didn't drink. "You remember what it felt like when we started? Like we were hacking into the future?"

He gave a sideways grin. "Yeah, before we realized the future was mostly just grant writing and GPU shortages."

She smiled. "And watching whatever we build become outdated within six months."

He clinked his glass against hers. "To brilliance with a shelf life!"

She drank this time, but only a sip. Then she rested her forearms on the sticky tabletop and glanced toward the door, as if expecting someone to walk in and change the subject.

"You okay?" Daniel asked.

"Yeah. I've just been… thinking."

"Uh-oh. Dangerous pastime."

"Shut up."

He leaned back and gave her space.

"I don't know," she said. "Doesn't it ever bother you? What we're building?"

Daniel tilted his head. “Define ‘bother’.”

“The direction it’s all going. The scale of it. Like… when we started, I thought AI would empower people. Now it feels like we might just replace them.”

“That’s not on us,” he said, with a shrug. “We’re doing foundational work. It’s not like we’re using it to code auto-attendants for call centers. We leave that grunt work to lesser beings”, he concluded, with a haughty smirk and a wink of irony.

“Sure, but the foundational tools we build, they *become* the auto-attendants. And the ultrasound technicians. Then the legal aides and tax consultants.”

He scratched his beard. “You’re really going down the doom spiral tonight.”

She sighed. “Look, I’m not saying we shut it all down. I’m just saying we should think more about where this leads.”

Daniel took another drink. “Okay, sure. Here’s where it leads: companies save billions by not paying bored middle managers to write reports no one reads. Customers get answers in seconds. And you and I get to make a million or two in the process. Or, if that’s not your thing, you get to move on to harder problems.”

“Like what?”

“Artificial General Intelligence, Digital Consciousness, Artificial Life, whatever comes after GPT-what-the-hell. Do you know how many people still work as billing clerks? Data entry? Scheduling assistants? That’s not human potential. That’s busywork waiting to be automated.”

“And when it’s all automated?”

“Then we get universal basic income, and everyone becomes an artist.”

Lena chuckled. “Right.”

“I’m serious.”

“No, you’re not.”

He smiled. “Okay, I’m halfway serious.”

She let the silence sit for a moment before saying, “You don’t ever feel responsible?”

“For what?”

“For what happens to all the people who can’t adapt? Who don’t have a PhD in AI? Whose jobs may vanish and never come back?”

Daniel raised an eyebrow. “Do you think Edison felt responsible for every candle maker who lost their job to electric lights?”

“That’s different.”

“Why?”

She opened her mouth, then closed it. “Because… I don’t know. Maybe it’s not.”

He took a long pull from his drink, then set the glass down with finality.

“Look,” he said, softer now. “I get it. You’re thoughtful. You care. That’s part of what makes you the wonderful person you are. But at the end of the day, this is happening. With or without us. We can either be part of shaping it, or we can step aside and let less scrupulous people run the show.”

Lena looked at him for a long time.

“You always know how to make being cynical sound noble.”

He grinned. “It’s a gift.”

They paid their tab around midnight. The wind outside had picked up, sharp with an early spring bite, and the wet streets were littered with bits of discarded flyers and fast food wrappers.

Daniel fished his helmet out of his backpack and put it on. The glossy, opened black visor reflected the orange halo of the streetlight.

“You sure you’re good to ride?” Lena asked.

He tapped the side of the helmet. “Just buzzed enough to feel invincible.”

“Maybe take it easy tonight.”

“I always take it easy.”

She gave him a look.

“Okay, I *usually* take it easy.”

She shook her head, smiling despite herself.

“Seriously, though,” he added, as he slung a leg over his LiveWire motorcycle, its angular frame gleaming under the sodium glow. “Try not to stress so much about the future. If anyone’s job is safe, it’s ours.”

“I am not just worried about my job,” she objected indignantly.

“I know,” he said with a smile, before waving his hand and adding: “Night Dr Goody Two-Shoes”.

“Night, Professor Mayhem.”

The electric motor whispered to life, a high, fast whine like a swarm of bees trapped in a bottle. And just like that, he was off. No engine growl. No throaty roar. Just a rush of wind and the barely-audible sizzle of electric speed. The acceleration was instant; brutally smooth, like being pulled forward by an invisible thread.

It always amazed him how something so quiet could move so fast. The silent, sealed helmet created a perfect chamber for Lena’s warm, melodic voice to echo in his head.

You sure you’re good to ride?

He was. Mostly. Maybe a little loose at the edges, but nothing he hadn’t handled before.

The streets near the university were quiet, except for a food truck still wrapping up business and a couple of undergrads arguing about the ethics of machine consciousness over a slice of greasy pizza.

The whir of the engine beneath him was almost meditative, a mood amplified by the city lights shimmering in reflections across windshields and puddles, and the quiet hum of late-night traffic.

The truth was, he loved riding. It was one of the few things he didn’t want automated. He hated those rider assist features that checked his blindsides for him, or warned him when his mount went off track, and he had deactivated the lot of them upon purchase. All he wanted was him, the machine, and the road.

He drove through the financial district, where traffic lights grew further apart and the urban skyline gave way to long strips of residential apartments and closed office parks. On impulse, he took a detour through the old industrial neighborhood. The roads were uneven here: half-patched potholes and badly lit intersections. But it was quiet. Clear.

A perfect stretch for thinking.

If anyone’s job is safe, it’s ours.

That’s what he’d said. It sounded smug now, even in his own head. He imagined Lena rolling her eyes as she walked home, probably composing an angry-but-thoughtful blog post in her mind about intellectual hubris.

Still, she worried too much. People had always panicked about automation: loom workers, switchboard operators, bank tellers and cashiers. And yet the world adapted. It always did. That was the story of progress: discomfort, then adjustment, then something better.

Wasn’t it?

Daniel turned a corner and rolled his bike to a stop at the red light. The motor clicked off with quiet precision. To his right, a hulking figure on a battered Harley rested a heavy boot on the asphalt, one hand clenched tight around a worn handlebar.

The man was a warning on wheels: leather jacket patched with faded gang insignias, a long braided beard streaked with gray, and eyes that cut like a switch blade. Thick chains hung from his belt loops, clinking softly as he shifted weight and glared at Daniel. His lips curled into a sneer, as he twisted the throttle aggressively, his hog growling beneath him, mocking his neighbour’s geeky ride.

Daniel smirked beneath his visor and mimed a pretend rev gesture, fingers slowly stroking the throttle in a circular motion that produced no sound whatsoever. Then he tilted his head toward the red light — a clear challenge: *You wanna race?*

The biker’s eyes narrowed dangerously. He leaned forward, a snarl curling the corner of his mouth. Without a word, he pulled down his scratched riding goggles, scarred and faded from years of wear, and nodded.

Green.

The classic Harley blasted forward, a thunderous beast unleashed, but Daniel’s high tech machine surged instantly ahead, the electric motor humming low but fierce beneath him. Torque hit with a whisper-quiet punch, propelling him past the roaring antique.

Adrenaline sharpened his every sense. The city blurred as they tore towards the next intersection.

And that’s when it happened.

A sleek black BMW SUV, a glossy favorite among stock brokers and corporate lawyers, emerged from a barely visible side street, recklessly burning its traffic light at breakneck speed.

Daniel grabbed the brakes hard. The tires squealed, then skidded, hydroplaning on the wet asphalt. There was no traction control to intervene. Daniel had disabled it like all the rest, in his pursuit for a pure, more visceral ride. The bike jerked sideways and struck the raised median at an angle.

The impact catapulted him into the air. He twisted mid-flight, limbs flailing like a puppet with its strings cut. The night sky tilted, then spun violently as he slammed into the far lane. Pain bloomed white-hot through his body.

Time stuttered and his head swam, as the world around him rapidly came in and out of focus.

The last thing he saw through the haze was the biker's face hunched over him. His thuggishness had melted away, replaced by an expression of deep and genuine concern.

"Hang in there bro," he said with a hoarse, yet comforting voice.

Daniel tried to respond, but his vision faded and he lost consciousness.

The luxury SUV was nowhere to be seen. Its driver had fled into the night like a common thief.

First came the sounds. Soft, clinical, repetitive. A gentle beep. A hiss. Rhythms not his own.

They pulled at him like distant voices underwater.

Then, the light. Pale and sourceless, blooming behind his eyelids.

He opened his eyes.

The ceiling above him was unfamiliar: a grid of white tiles, one with a small brown stain in the corner, as if someone had spilled tea and not bothered to clean it up. Harsh, clinical lights cast a cold, unyielding glow over everything, bathing the room in sterile whiteness.

Daniel blinked again. He tried to shift his body, but only felt a vague, dull ache deep inside — an indistinct pressure rather than sharp pain.

Nothing moved. His limbs lay still, unresponsive.

He tried to shift his head. No response. Tried to flex his fingers. Nothing. Not even a whisper of motion.

Panic came slowly, like ink dropped in water, tendrils curling outward, unfurling inside him.

A voice interrupted it.

"Daniel?"

A woman leaned into view. Blonde hair pulled back. A pale blue uniform. No recognition in her face. Professional concern, nothing more.

"If you can hear me, blink twice."

He did.

Her expression softened. She exhaled, just once, and smiled.

The days that followed were a haze of tests, procedures, and endless boredom. A string of nurses – doctors seemed oddly absent from the premises – explained the basics. Cautiously,

always cautiously. A brain injury. Spinal trauma. “Locked-in syndrome.” That phrase came up a lot. A mind intact, a body uncooperative.

They fitted him with an EEG cap connected to some new fangled brain-machine interface. They said he could write text on a screen by just thinking about it. But it was klunky, slow and unreliable. He had to focus hard on one word at a time, and it took more than a second for the machine to register and print them in turn. And more often than not, it got them completely wrong.

In the end, he relied almost exclusively on the older but more reliable eye-tracking system, which allowed him to spell words by gazing at letters on the screen. It was still slow and awkward but, combined with automatic word completion, it was something. It gave him a sliver of hope for the future.

HOW LONG IN COMA, he wrote, soon after becoming comfortable with the setup.

“Five years”, came the nurse’s reluctant response.

It was on the tenth day that Lena came.

She stepped into the room quietly and sheepishly, like she wasn’t sure she was allowed to be there. Her hair was shorter, blunt and practical, and her clothes were simple, earth-toned and unbranded. There were faint crows feet at the corner of her eyes, which hadn’t been there before. But her appearance was still Lena: spine straight, arms loose, eyes sharp.

He blinked once.

She walked to the bed and sat beside it.

“Hey, asshole,” she said softly. “You missed your thesis defense.”

If he could have laughed, he would have.

Instead, he typed: **SORRY**

“I guess you had a pretty good excuse.”

He looked at her longer this time, almost accusingly. She swallowed, and her voice became teary.

“They wouldn’t let me see you at first. Said it was for immediate family only. I kept calling, though. Every day.”

NEVERMIND, he wrote, **HOW U BEEN?**

“OK, I guess, considering…”, she answered, her unfinished sentence hanging in the air.

After a long and laborious chit chat – **HOW IS EVERYBODY?**, **MY CATS OK?**, Lena carefully breached the subject that was eating at her.

“You probably want to know what’s been going on … tech wise?”

YES

“Alright,” she said, leaning back a little. “Short version: the future arrived while you were taking your nap.”

She paused, as if deciding where to begin.

“You remember Galileo?” she asked. “The reasoning model everyone said was going to hit a wall?”

YES

“Well, it didn’t.”

She smiled without humor.

“After that, things just… snowballed. The machine quickly came up with a succession of breakthroughs. Self modifying code and architectures, Neural Turing Machines, Meta-Learning, Neuromorphic chips. Oh, and of course, purpose-built AIs for every damn cognitive task you can imagine. They’re not just completing sentences anymore, Daniel. They’re writing legal briefs, diagnosing illnesses, designing buildings and new drugs, and writing software, sometimes modifying their own code. Remember how we joked that we would all be artists? Well that’s gone too. Hell, they’re even peer reviewing each other’s papers now.”

He said nothing. The cursor hovered over blank space.

“And the craziest part? It’s *cheap*. Like, free app cheap. White-collar and intellectual jobs just… vanished.”

INCLUDING OURS

She looked at him.

“Yeah. Including ours.”

The next day she brought a tablet.

“Thought you might want some entertainment,” she said. “News, movies, music, whatever.”

He gazed at the News icon, so she clicked on it and scrolled through the feed on his behalf.

“It’s all produced by machines now of course,” she added with a wistful expression.

She kept scrolling, headline after headline.

UNIVERSITY ANNOUNCES COMPLETE CURRICULUM SHIFT TO AI-SUPERVISED LEARNING

GOVERNMENT EXPANDS BASIC INCOME AMID WHITE COLLAR SECTOR COLLAPSE

90% OF TECH JOBS AUTOMATED IN LAST FIVE YEARS

Daniel stared at them one at a time.

WHAT JOBS REMAIN?

She hesitated.

“Manual ones,” she said. “Stuff AI can’t do yet. Not well, anyway. Construction trades, cooking, agriculture. Nursing, obviously,” she added, turning towards the hallway where human personnel kept rushing past the door. “Doctors, well, that’s a different story. The only jobs left are those that require some sort of physical competence in an open, uncontrolled environment.”

She didn’t say what they were both thinking.

He typed it instead: **I CAN’T DO THOSE**

“No,” she admitted. “You can’t.”

She looked down at her hands. When she spoke again, her voice had changed.

“It’s not just you. Most academics and techies are out of work. There are people with triple degrees earning their living by delivering packages now. Or trying to. Even that’s getting automated.”

WHAT ABOUT YOU?

“I’m doing better than most,” she said. “I consult. Ethics boards. Policy circles. Mostly performative. Mostly ignored.”

YOU WERE RIGHT

She looked up sharply. “Don’t say that.”

YOU WERE

She shook her head. “None of us were right. We were all blindsided in some way or another. Those who say they weren't are just rewriting their own history.”

In the following weeks, Lena visited more often.

They talked about small things—TV shows (AI-generated), new music (composed and performed by machines), her brother’s woodworking hobby (still a human craft, for now).

But it always came back to the same questions.

Not just what had changed.

But what remained.

One day, she asked, “If you could move and speak again, what’s the first thing you’d do?”

He stared at the screen a long time before replying.

I DON’T KNOW

Then, slowly: **EVERYTHING I WANTED TO DO IS GONE**

Lena looked at the screen, then at him. Her face didn’t change right away. She just sat with the words, letting them hang on the sterile computer screen.

“Yeah,” she said quietly. “I know.”

She got up, paced a few slow steps to the window. Outside, the city buzzed — not so much with cars and people like it used to, but with the low hum of drones and automated vans. Precision without pesky human oversight.

She turned back.

“I used to think life was all about accomplishment. Proving yourself. Earning your place. Being useful. Now I spend half my days arguing pointlessly with policy bots and the other half lying to thirty-something PhD graduates to convince them they’re not obsolete yet.”

Daniel watched her. The cursor blinked, waiting for his thoughts.

“But I’ve been thinking lately,” she went on, “maybe usefulness isn’t the whole story.”

He typed: **SO WHAT IS?**

She shrugged. “Maybe it’s just... connection. People you meet along the way and become close to. Maybe that’s what’s left.”

No words appeared on Daniel’s screen.

“Look, I don’t know what comes next. But you’re still here. You still *see, hear* and *think.* You still… *feel*. And that matters.”

TO WHO?

“How about me,” she replied, gazing at him with soft tender eyes that said it all.